



The Quiet Word

The five minutes of a one-to-one check-in, written down: how to open it, what you must not promise, what you write afterwards, and when it stops being yours to hold. Print pages 2 to 5 once, and cut out the card for a lanyard.

Before you start. This is not safeguarding training and it does not replace your school's child protection policy. Where the two disagree, the policy wins.

Print these

Page	What it is
Page 2	The five minutes: how to open it, the sentence about what you can keep to yourself, the silence, and how to finish.
Page 3	What to say instead. The eight openings a check-in usually reaches for, and what to ask in their place.
Page 4	When it stops being yours. The four things that go to your safeguarding lead the same day, and a card to cut out for a lanyard.
Page 5	The note. What you write down afterwards, three to a page.

How it works

Step	What happens
1	Pick the room before you pick the words. Somewhere the form cannot hear, with a door open or a window in it, and sit at the side of the desk rather than across it.
2	Open with what you noticed, not with a question. "You have been first out of that door all week" gives a student something to agree with. "Are you okay?" gives them one polite answer.
3	Say what you can and cannot keep to yourself before they tell you anything, not after. The sentence is on page 2, and it is the most important thing on it.
4	Leave the silence alone. Count to ten. Most students fill it, and what they fill it with is usually what they came to say.
5	Finish on what happens next and one thing you will do, with a day on it. Then write the note the same day, in their words rather than your summary.

Worth knowing

- Five minutes is a check-in. If it needs half an hour every week it belongs with your head of year rather than with you alone.
- A student who says nothing has still had the conversation. Name a day you will find them again, and then do it. That is the bit they watch for.
- Tell a colleague if it was a heavy one. Keep it from the rest of the form, but you can still talk it through with your own line manager.

The sheet is never the resource. The five minutes is.





The five minutes

The shape of a one-to-one check-in, from the door to the note. Read it once, keep it where you plan, and stop reading it after about the fourth time you have done this.

Before they sit down

Somewhere the rest of the form cannot hear it, and somewhere you can be seen. Door open, or a window in it. Sit at the side of the desk, not across it, and not between the student and the way out. Say how long you have: "I have got five minutes before period one." A conversation with a known end is easier to start.

The opening

Name the thing you noticed, plainly and small. "You have been first out of that door all week." "You have not been in the usual seat." "That is three Mondays." Then stop talking. You are not asking a question yet, you are giving them something true to agree with or correct.

The sentence about keeping it to yourself

Say it before they tell you anything, in your own words, and say it every time: "Most of what you say to me stays with me. If you tell me something that makes me worried about you being safe, or about somebody else, I have to pass it on. If that happens I will tell you I am doing it and who I am telling." Never promise that it stops with you. A promise you have to break is the last conversation you get.

The silence

When you have asked something, count to ten before you fill it. It will feel much longer than it is. Most students talk into that gap, and a good many of them say the real thing there rather than in the answer before it.

If nothing comes

That is a normal outcome and not a failed conversation. "Alright. I am going to find you again on Thursday after registration." Name the day, write it down in front of them, and turn up. Doing that twice is worth more than any single good question.

The close

Three things, in this order: what you have understood, what happens next and who else will be involved, and one thing you will do, with a day on it. Never end with nothing happening. If the answer is that nothing needs to happen, say that out loud, because otherwise they will assume something is happening and nobody told them.

Afterwards, same day

Write the note on page 5 while you still have their words. Their words, not your tidy version of them. Then, if any of page 4 applies, do page 4 before you go home.

If you only take one line off this page: say what you can and cannot keep to yourself before they start, not after.





What to say instead

None of the eight on the left is a bad person's question. They are what everybody reaches for when they care and have four minutes. The column in the middle is what gets you further.

Instead of	Try	Why it lands better
"Are you okay?"	"You have been quiet this week. I wanted to check."	A yes or no question has a polite answer, and the polite answer ends the conversation.
"Is everything alright at home?"	"How are things outside school at the minute?"	The first names the problem before the student has. The second leaves them room to say there is not one.
"It stays between us, I promise."	"Most of it stays with me. If I am worried about you being safe I have to pass it on, and I will tell you when I do."	A promise you cannot keep is the fastest way to lose a student, and everyone they talk to.
"Why did you do that?"	"What was going on for you at the time?"	Why asks for a justification, and gets one. The second question gets you what led up to it.
"Do you want to talk about it?"	Nothing. Wait.	The offer is already made by you sitting there. The silence does more work than the question does.
"Cheer up, it might never happen."	"That sounds hard."	Minimising is heard as being dismissed, and it is remembered a lot longer than you would think.
"I know exactly how you feel."	"I do not know what that is like. I am listening."	You probably do not, and claiming it quietly turns the conversation towards you.
"Let me know if you need anything."	"I will find you Thursday, after registration."	An open offer puts the work on the student, and they will not do it. A named day puts the work on you.

Read the left column as a warning about tone rather than about words. A student can tell the difference between being asked and being processed, and that is what they answer.





When it stops being yours

A check-in is yours to hold right up until one of these four turns up in it. At that point your job is to pass it on accurately and quickly, and nothing else.

The four

- Anything suggesting a student is not safe at home, or is being hurt or neglected by anybody.
- Anything about hurting themselves, wanting to be dead, or a plan to do either.
- Anything about another student or an adult that would worry you if it were your own child.
- Anything you are still carrying at half past four and cannot say why. Take that one seriously.

What you do

	What happens
Write it	Their words, on page 5 or on whatever form your school uses. What they said, not what you concluded.
Say it out loud	To your safeguarding lead, in person or on your school's system, the same day. Not by email alone.
Tell the student	That you are passing it on, and who to. You said you would at the start; this is the moment that sentence was for.
Ask what next	So you can answer the student when they ask, which they will, usually the next morning.

What you do not do

- Do not promise it stops with you, however much you want to.
- Do not investigate. No extra questions to get the details straight, and none to anybody else.
- Do not wait for the end of the week, for more evidence, or for it to happen twice.
- Do not take it home. Tell a colleague you have had a hard one, without the details.

Fill this in now, before you file the sheet

Safeguarding lead	
Deputy	
Where the report goes	
Out of hours or holidays	

✂

THE QUIET WORD

Pass it on the same day if it is about: safety at home, being hurt by anyone, hurting themselves or wanting to be dead, or anything you are still carrying at half past four.

Tell the student you are passing it on, and who to. Do not investigate it yourself.

Safeguarding lead **Deputy**





The note

Written the same day, in their words rather than your summary, and kept wherever your school keeps pastoral records rather than in your planner. Three to a page.

CHECK-IN NOTE	Student and form	Date and time
Why I checked in (what I noticed)		
What they said, in their words		
What I said I would do, and by when		
Passed to, and when		
Next check-in		

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